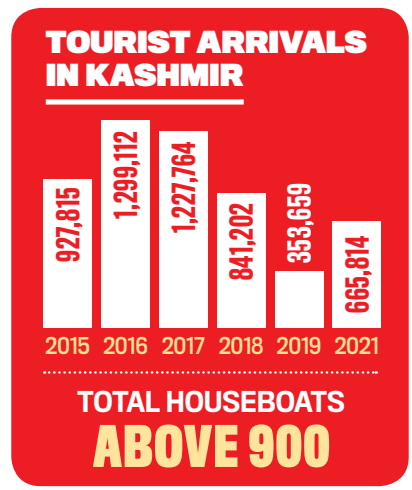


ANI

7,500 A DAY: KASHMIR'S TOURISM METER HAS BEEN BUZZING SINCE MARCH. SRINAGAR'S TULIP GARDEN IS SMILING

of May. Tariffs have broken the circuit barrier with a clean hike of, again, 100 per cent—a budget class accommodation you could score for Rs 1,000-1,500 is going for Rs 3,000 a night. And that's across Kashmir's grand total of 45,000 rooms. Srinagar airport and NH44, connecting Kashmir to the rest of India via the new twin-tube Banihal tunnel, have been bringing around 7,500 tourists daily from March. Some 350,000 tourists have arrived this year. March alone brought 180,000, just in time to soak in Asia's biggest tulip garden, in Srinagar, that reopened on March 23—brimming with all 68 varieties of the flower across its 20 acres.

An unforeseen spring, it has saved people like Riyaz; thousands of those plunged into penury have found jobs. "My boat is booked for April and I am getting more bookings," says Riyaz, who inherited his intricately carved houseboat from his father. "We're expecting a record tourist season," says Ahsan Chisti, deputy director, Kashmir tourism. "We used the pandemic years to draw strategies, run campaigns and meet stakeholders." In September 2020, the department did outreach programmes with stakeholders in Indian cities. It organised spring and autumn festivals—an invite to prospective tourists.



Guide Ghulam Qadir of Bandipora reminisces about the rush of foreign trekkers in the '80s. That's just before militancy struck, and authorities shut trekking routes—and tourist numbers fell to an annual low of 6,000. After that nadir, people like Qadir had quit the profession. This year's calm has emboldened authorities to offer adventure tourism once again. Sarmad Hafeez, tourism and culture secretary, says they are opening 75 destinations, including high-altitude ones like Gurez and Bangus valleys, close to the LoC in north Kashmir. Both were off-limits once, but with the India-Pakistan ceasefire pact of February 2021 holding, they are back on the tourism map. Lt Governor Manoj Sinha lauds the Centre for the boom, citing the record budget allocation of Rs 786 crore for tourism—a hike of Rs 509 crore. Pilgrimage is part of the scheme: 20 religious places in Srinagar have been identified for renovation. In Jammu, the state has roped in the ASI to restore tourist magnets like the Mubarak Mandi heritage complex and the Amar Singh Palace etc.

A lull in militancy could help fructify the plan of attracting Rs 70,000 crore investment—a UAE business delegation has shown interest. This season is being compared to 2016, when over 1.2 million visited the Valley. That surge tapered off after the Burhan Wani killing that July sparked months of unrest. A blemish-free season now would help. ■